

Past lives

Unit 6 of 12 · Grammar Study Sheet

Talk about people, places, and events in the past using was/were and the past simple.

What you will be able to do

- ✓ Use the verb be in the past (was/were)
- ✓ Use the past simple to talk about finished events
- ✓ Ask and answer questions about the past
- ✓ Use time expressions (yesterday, in 1799, last March...)
- ✓ Use opinion adjectives
- ✓ Ask what people did last night / at the weekend
- ✓ Write formal and informal thank-you messages

4 lessons in this unit

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Topics: famous faces · was/were · past simple regular · time expressions · -ed endings

Vocabulary — Famous faces & money

president	queen	scientist	musician
writer	artist	currency	note
coin	dollar	euro	pound
peso			

Famous on money: George Washington (US 1-dollar), Frida Kahlo & Diego Rivera (Mexican 500-peso), Queen Elizabeth (UK notes). Euro notes show buildings/maps — NO famous people.

Vocabulary — Time expressions (past → present)

when I was a child	before the 18th century	in 1799	during the 19th century
the sixties	in 2000	last March	a week ago
last Monday evening	on January 1st, 2000	yesterday	this morning

Use **IN** with months/years/centuries (in 1799). Use **ON** with specific dates (on January 1st). Use **ago** AFTER the number (a week ago).

Pronunciation — -ed endings: /t/, /d/, /ɪd/

The "-ed" ending of regular past verbs has THREE sounds.

- /t/ — after voiceless sounds (k, p, s, ʃ, tʃ, f): liked, worked, watched, finished
- /d/ — after voiced sounds (b, g, l, m, n, v, vowels): lived, played, travelled, called
- /ɪd/ — after t or d sounds (EXTRA syllable): wanted, started, visited, painted, decided

was / were — past simple of "be"

I/he/she/it → was. You/we/they → were. Same negative and question patterns as present.

+	George Washington WAS the first US president.
–	His face WASN'T on the dollar. There WEREN'T any famous people on euros.
?	When WAS he born? WERE they famous? Yes, they were. / No, they weren't.

Examples:

- I was a child in the nineties.
- They were Mexican artists.
- Where were you yesterday? — I was at home.
- Was she at home? — Yes, she was. / No, she wasn't.

Past simple — regular verbs

Use the past simple for FINISHED actions and events in the past. Regular verbs add -ed.

+	verb + -ed (worked, lived, studied, travelled)
spell.	-e → +d (live → lived). Consonant + y → -ied (study → studied). BrE doubles -l (travel → travelled).

Examples:

- They worked in Mexico City.
- He lived in the 18th century.
- She studied art.
- They travelled in Europe.
- Frida painted self-portraits.

Lesson 6b · Visiting the past

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Topics: visiting the past · past simple irregular · past simple negative · past simple questions

Vocabulary — Visiting the past — Mustang caves

cave	mountain	century	river
family	humans	Mustang region	Nepal

Yandu Bista grew up in a cave in northern Nepal. Humans made these caves about 3,000 years ago. People lived in them until the 15th century. Yandu's family moved to a town, but she says: "I like living in a cave."

Past simple — irregular verbs

Many common verbs do NOT add -ed. They have their own past form. Learn them by heart!

Examples:

- go → went have → had do → did
- make → made bring → brought build → built
- grow → grew leave → left see → saw
- meet → met take → took write → wrote
- come → came get → got buy → bought
- See page 182 of the textbook for a full list of irregular verbs.

Past simple — negatives and questions

For ALL subjects (I/you/he/she/it/we/they): didn't + base verb. Did + subject + base verb? Use the BASE form after did/didn't — NOT the past form.

+	I/he/she/it/we/they grew up in a cave.
–	I/he/she/it/we/they DIDN'T live in a house. (NOT "didn't lived")
?	What DID you DO at the weekend? — I met some friends.
Y/N	DID you go to the cinema? — Yes, I did. / No, I didn't.

Examples:

- They didn't have water in the cave.
- She didn't live in a house.
- Where did you go yesterday? — I went to the museum.
- Did you have fun? — Yes, I did.
- NOTE: For "be" use was/were directly: Were they at home? — Yes, they were.

Lesson 6c · Lifelogging

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Topics: lifelogging · word focus: write

Vocabulary — Lifelogging

diary	lifelogger	blog	photographs
fitness tracker	video	comments	social media

Samuel Pepys (17th century) wrote the most famous diary in English. Gordon Bell became the first "lifelogger" in 2000 — he wore a camera that automatically took a picture every 30 seconds. Today we lifelog with photos, social media posts, and fitness trackers.

Word focus: write

The verb "write" combines with different prepositions and objects to make different meanings.

Examples:

- write ABOUT history — the topic of your writing
- write A diary — what you write (an article/journal)
- write TO your grandparents — the person you send to
- write DOWN a word — note it on paper (phrasal verb)

Lesson 6d · How was your evening? + Thanks! + objects video

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Topics: asking what people did · opinion adjectives · intonation · thank you messages · formal and informal · video lesson · museum objects

Vocabulary — Opinion adjectives (positive → negative) (6d)

fantastic / great / very good 😊	OK / fine / nice / not bad 😊	funny 😄	boring 😞
terrible / not very good 😞			

fun = enjoyable (an activity). funny = makes you laugh (a joke, a film). They are NOT the same!

Vocabulary — Video — Objects from the past (6f)

museum	object	history	precious
ancient	discover	century	civilization

Pronunciation — Intonation — matching your tone to your opinion (6d)

Strong opinions need lively/animated intonation. Neutral opinions sound flat. Make your voice match how you feel.

- "Fantastic!" — enthusiastic, voice goes up
- "Terrible!" — strong falling tone, drawn out
- "OK" / "Fine" — flat, neutral
- "Not bad" with flat tone = slightly positive (British understatement)

Real life — Asking what people did (6d)

Useful phrases for asking and answering about past events.

Examples:

- How was your evening / weekend / holiday?
- Did you have a good evening / weekend? Did you have a good time?
- Did you have fun last night? — It was great / fun / OK / not much.
- Activity: What did you do? — I went for a walk. / I watched TV.
- Place: Where did you go? — To a café / a party / the cinema.
- People: Who were you with? — A friend / friends / my family.
- How many: Were there many people there? — Yes, lots! / No, not many.

Writing skill — Formal vs informal thank-you messages (6e)

Match the style to your relationship. Informal for friends/family; formal for clients/teachers/strangers.

Greet	Informal: Hi! / Hello! · Formal: Dear Mr/Mrs Smith,
Thank	Informal: Thanks for... · Formal: Thank you very much for...
Future	Informal: See you again soon! · Formal: I look forward to hearing from you.
End	Informal: Love / Cheers / Bye · Formal: Yours sincerely / Best regards

Examples:

- Informal: "Hi! Thanks for coming to my party. I really liked the present! See you again soon. Love, Ginny"
- Formal: "Dear Nadia, Thank you very much for your work in Rio. The conference was very successful. Best regards, Sanjit"